

GA-ED-01

Engaged Teaching, Differentiation & Cognitive Challenge

A practical standard for creative, participatory learning that responds to learner differences and develops higher-order thinking.

APPLIES TO

Gardner Academy employees and relevant staff

AUTHORITY

Gardner Culture and instructional practice standard

01 Purpose

This policy establishes Gardner Academy's expectation that teaching should actively invite participation, honour learner differences, and provide meaningful cognitive challenge. Engagement is planned through thoughtful experiences, relationships, questions, materials, and opportunities to create.

02 Policy statement

Teachers must make every reasonable effort to design learning that is creative, purposeful, and engaging. Planning and delivery should reflect differentiated learning and use Bloom's Taxonomy to develop thinking beyond simple recall. Engagement does not mean constant entertainment; it means students have an active, meaningful role in learning.

03 Engagement expectations

Learning experiences should:

- Begin with a clear purpose, meaningful question, problem, experience, or invitation.
- Connect with prior knowledge, student interests, real contexts, or an authentic audience where appropriate.
- Use active exploration, discussion, collaboration, movement, making, investigation, or choice rather than relying mainly on passive listening or repetitive worksheets.
- Include opportunities for imagination, curiosity, revision, problem-solving, and student voice.
- Use ongoing checks for understanding and adjust when students are confused, disengaged, or insufficiently challenged.

04 Differentiated learning

Differentiation responds to evidence about learners. Teachers should adjust content, process, support, challenge, environment, pacing, or the way students demonstrate understanding. Differentiation provides multiple pathways towards worthwhile learning goals; it does not mean lowering expectations or preparing an unrelated lesson for every student.

05 Bloom's Taxonomy

Across a sequence of learning, students should have opportunities to remember, understand, apply, analyse, evaluate, and create. Every lesson does not need to include every level, but planning should deliberately move students beyond recall towards using knowledge, examining relationships, making reasoned judgements, and producing something new.

06 Planning and evidence

Planning should identify the learning intention, likely learner differences, key questions or tasks, supports and extensions, opportunities for active participation, and how understanding will be checked. Teachers should reflect on evidence of engagement and learning, then adapt future planning.

07 Shared academic responsibility

All staff members may be called upon to assist with the planning, preparation, collaboration, or implementation of academic resources and learning experiences where the assigned work is reasonable and lawful.

Depending on the employee's training, background, role, and the needs of the school, this may include:

- Assisting with non-academic supervision that supports a safe and effective learning experience.
- Supporting or delivering academic instruction suited to the employee's training and background.
- Preparing, organising, adapting, or distributing learning resources and materials.
- Contributing to planning, preparation, or implementation for another class, programme, subject, or department.
- Collaborating with colleagues before, during, or after a learning experience.

These examples are not exhaustive. Employees must carry out reasonable and lawful assigned support, ask for clarification when expectations are unclear, and immediately raise any concern about training, competence, authorisation, or student safety before performing a task.

08 Accountability

Teachers must participate in required planning, observation, feedback, coaching, or professional-development activities connected to this standard. Repeated failure to prepare or deliver learning that meets the required standard may be addressed through the applicable performance or disciplinary process.